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THE INDIAN

WINTER AIR POLLUTION SURVIVAL PLAYBOOK 2026

Delhi-NCR and Beyond | The revised GRAP, masks, purifiers,
indoor air and your health - explained simply and verified.

First Edition | Facts verified October 2026

Breathe safer this smog season.

SECTION

How to use this playbook

Read once, then keep it on your phone for the season.

Every winter, from late October to January, air quality across north and central India falls into a predictable crisis. In Delhi-NCR the Air Quality Index (AQI) crosses 300 for weeks, schools shut, construction stops, and hospitals see a spike in coughs, asthma attacks and breathlessness. This playbook is written for the person who has to live through it - a parent, a student, a commuter, an office-goer, or someone managing asthma or a heart condition at home.

It is deliberately practical. You will not find long theory here. Instead you get: how to read the AQI correctly, what the 2026 Delhi-NCR Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) actually says after it was revised on 28 September 2026, which mask works and which is a waste of money, how to choose an air purifier without being fooled by marketing, how to cut the pollution you make inside your own home, and the small daily habits that protect your lungs.

Everything here is verified against official and current sources - the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), the Supreme Court's 2026 firecracker proceedings, WHO air-quality guidance, peer-reviewed studies, and 2026 Indian product listings. Prices and rules change; the date of verification is stated so you always know how fresh it is.

A word on honesty

This is a health-protection guide, not medical advice. If you have asthma, COPD, heart disease, or you are pregnant, use this as a checklist and confirm every step with your own doctor. Where the science is uncertain, this playbook says so instead of pretending.

What is inside

- **Part 1** - Know the enemy: PM2.5, PM10 and why winter is worse
- **Part 2** - Read the AQI like a pro (the six official categories)
- **Part 3** - The 2026 Delhi-NCR rulebook: the revised GRAP, stage by stage
- **Part 4** - Check your own air: apps, timing and what the numbers mean
- **Part 5** - The mask guide: N95, KN95, N99 and what to ignore
- **Part 6** - The air purifier guide: HEPA, CADR and verified 2026 prices
- **Part 7** - Fix your indoor air: the sources you control
- **Part 8** - Protect your body: hydration, diet, breathing, exercise
- **Part 9** - High-risk groups and when to see a doctor
- **Part 10** - The Diwali 2026 plan (8 November)
- **Part 11** - Your daily routine, 30-day plan and printable checklists

SECTION

Part 1 - Know the enemy

Three things are in the air - and only one is visible

Smog looks like one grey haze, but it is a mix. The two that matter most for your health are particulate matter - **PM10** (particles under 10 micrometres) and **PM2.5** (under 2.5 micrometres). PM2.5 is the dangerous one: it is small enough to slip past the nose and throat, reach the deepest air sacs of the lungs, and even cross into the bloodstream. Alongside these particles sit gases - nitrogen dioxide (NO₂) and sulphur dioxide (SO₂) from vehicles and industry, carbon monoxide (CO), ozone (O₃), and volatile organic compounds (VOCs) from burning and solvents.

The World Health Organization's guideline for PM2.5 is an annual average of 5 micrograms per cubic metre (ug/m³) and a 24-hour average of 15 ug/m³. On a severe Delhi winter day, 24-hour PM2.5 is routinely several times that, and India has repeatedly been home to 13 of the world's 25 most polluted cities. That gap between the guideline and reality is exactly why a survival plan matters.

Why winter is worse than summer

Winter brings a weather condition called **temperature inversion**. Normally, warm air near the ground rises and carries pollution away. In winter, cold air settles below a layer of warmer air and acts like a lid, trapping vehicle fumes, construction dust and crop-residue smoke close to the ground where you breathe. Add lower wind speeds, festive firecrackers, and stubble burning in Punjab and Haryana carried in by north-westerly winds, and the result is the smog season. This is not bad luck - it is a repeatable seasonal pattern, which is why a fixed routine works.

The one-line takeaway

The number to watch is PM2.5. Everything in this playbook - masking, purifiers, indoor habits, timing your day - is aimed at the single job of lowering how much PM2.5 you and your family breathe.

SECTION

Part 2 - Read the AQI like a pro

India's National Air Quality Index, built by the Central Pollution Control Board, turns a soup of pollutant readings into one number and one colour. It uses the **worst** sub-index among the pollutants measured, so a single bad pollutant can push the whole AQI up. For Delhi-NCR the reported city figure is an average across monitoring stations, so your own locality can be better or worse than the headline number.

AQI	Category	What it means for your health
0 - 50	Good	Minimal impact. Air is clean.
51 - 100	Satisfactory	Minor breathing discomfort to sensitive people.
101 - 200	Moderate	Breathing discomfort for people with lung, asthma and heart disease.
201 - 300	Poor	Breathing discomfort to most people on prolonged exposure.
301 - 400	Very Poor	Respiratory illness on prolonged exposure. Children, elderly and the ill need added protection.
401 - 500	Severe	Affects healthy people and seriously impacts those with existing disease.

Source: CPCB National Air Quality Index. Note: CAQM's GRAP adds a further sub-division - Stage IV is invoked at AQI above 450 ('Severe+').

What to do at each band

- **Good to Satisfactory (0-100):** normal activity. A good window to open windows and air the house.
- **Moderate (101-200):** sensitive people reduce long or intense outdoor exertion; watch for symptoms.
- **Poor (201-300):** avoid outdoor exercise; wear a mask for long commutes; keep windows shut at peak hours.
- **Very Poor (301-400):** limit outdoor exposure, run a purifier in the room you sleep in, protect children and the elderly.
- **Severe (401-500):** avoid unnecessary outdoor activity, mask up if you must go out, and reduce exposure immediately.

Do not trust a single reading

AQI moves hour by hour. A morning reading of 420 can fall to 180 by early afternoon when sun and wind help disperse pollutants. Check the AQI before you plan outdoor time - not once a day, but before each outing.

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Part 3 - The 2026 Delhi-NCR rulebook

The Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) is the graded set of emergency measures CAQM triggers as Delhi's air worsens. On **28 September 2026**, CAQM's Full Commission approved a revised GRAP schedule for the NCR, ahead of the winter season. It matters to you because it decides when construction halts, which vehicles are barred, and what citizens are told to do. Here is the revised structure.

Stage	Delhi AQI	Meaning
Stage I	201 - 300	Poor
Stage II	301 - 400	Very Poor
Stage III	401 - 450	Severe
Stage IV	above 450	Severe +

What changed in the 2026 revision

- The revised schedule now carries **48 actions**: 25 under Stage I, 8 under Stage II, 10 under Stage III and 5 under Stage IV.
- Diesel generator (DG) sets and the entry of BS-IV and below buses from NCR and adjoining states were **moved from Stage II to Stage I** - they now bite earlier.
- The restriction on **BS-III petrol and BS-IV diesel four-wheelers** under Stage III was extended to **Sonipat**, in addition to Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad and Gautam Budh Nagar.
- The exemption that let **BS-IV and below goods vehicles** carrying essential commodities keep running under Stages III and IV was **removed** (LGVs and MGVs at Stage III; trucks and HGVs at Stage IV).
- The **Citizens Charter** - the official do's and don'ts for residents - was expanded from 22 to 34 actions.
- Monitoring of construction and demolition sites was extended beyond municipal limits to development areas, industrial zones and highway corridors.

What authorities announced for the season

Alongside GRAP, the Delhi government and the Union Environment Ministry set out season measures including a construction ban from 1 November, work-from-home for government employees on the worst days, and restrictions on polluting vehicles. These are implemented as the AQI crosses the relevant thresholds, so the practical advice is simple: assume they can start any week from late October.

What this means for you, in practice

Watch for the stage announcements - they are your early warning. When Stage III or IV is invoked, expect construction near you to stop, older diesel vehicles to disappear from the roads, and official advisories asking children, the elderly and the unwell to stay indoors. Plan your week around it: shift outdoor errands, school runs and exercise to the cleaner hours.

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Part 4 - Check your own air

The apps that matter

- **Sameer / CPCB** - the official Central Pollution Control Board app and website (airquality.cpcb.gov.in) give you the government AQI for your city and station. This is the number the rules are based on.
- **IQAir AirVisual** - widely used, gives locality-level PM2.5 and a forecast, and can show individual monitor stations near you. Useful for neighbourhood-level differences.
- A cheap **indoor PM2.5 monitor** (many cost under Rs 5,000) turns guesswork into data - it tells you whether your kitchen, bedroom or purifier is actually working.

Timing your day around the air

Pollution is not flat across the day. It usually peaks in the **evening and early morning**, when the inversion is strongest and traffic and burning add to it, and eases slightly in the **early afternoon** as sunlight and wind mix the air. So: do outdoor exercise or long commutes in the cleaner window when you can, keep windows shut at peak hours, and if you must ventilate the house, do it briefly in the day rather than at dawn or night.

The 60-second morning routine

Before you step out: check the AQI. Above 150 - take an N95 for the commute. Above 200 - skip outdoor exercise entirely and move it indoors. Above 300 - keep children, the elderly and anyone with a lung or heart condition indoors, and run the purifier.

SECTION

Part 5 - The mask guide

Masks are the cheapest, most immediate protection you own - but only if you choose the right type and wear it properly. The rating on a mask tells you the percentage of fine particles down to 0.3 microns that it filters in testing. PM2.5 sits right in that range, so the rating is directly relevant.

Mask / rating	Filters	Verdict for Indian smog
N95 (NIOSH)	95% of fine particles	The practical standard. Buy this.
KN95 / FFP2	Equivalent to N95	Equally good - often cheaper and easier to find.
N99 / FFP3	99% of fine particles	More protection; useful if you are very sensitive.
N100	99.97% of particles	Highest filtration; heavier - for extreme conditions.
Surgical / cloth	Large droplets only	Largely useless against PM2.5. Do not rely on it.

Fit is everything

A perfect filter with a leaky seal protects you far less than the rating suggests. Research on mask fit has measured total inward leakage of soot ranging from roughly **3% to 68%** depending on mask design and how well it sits on the face - and cloth masks remove only about 15% of particles the size of diesel emissions. So: press the metal nose clip down, check there is no gap at the cheeks, and adjust the straps. Facial hair reduces the seal.

Small details that matter

- Masks with an **exhaust valve** are easier to breathe in but let your exhaled air out - fine for personal protection, less ideal if you are also trying to protect others from infection.
- Wear a mask outdoors when AQI is above about **150**, and on any long commute, near traffic, or at construction sites even below that.
- Reuse N95/KN95 masks only while they stay clean, dry and undistorted - typically a few days of normal use, not weeks. Discard a mask that is soiled, damp or creased at the seal.
- Children need child-sized masks; an adult mask on a small face leaks badly. Do not mask infants.

SECTION

Part 6 - The air purifier guide

A purifier is the single biggest lever on the air you actually breathe, because Indians now spend most of their time indoors. But the category is full of inflated claims. Two specifications decide whether a machine works; everything else is decoration.

1) The filter must be True HEPA H13 (or H14)

True HEPA **H13** captures 99.95% of particles at 0.3 microns; **H14** captures 99.995%. 'HEPA-type', 'H11' or a vague '99.9% of PM2.5' claim is weaker and traps far less of the fine dust that matters. You also want a **separate activated-carbon layer** - that is what clears cooking smells, smoke and VOCs, which a HEPA-only unit will not.

2) Match the CADR to your room

CADR (Clean Air Delivery Rate, in m3/h) is how much clean air the unit pushes out. A practical rule used by Indian reviewers: **CADR (m3/h) should be at least 5 times your room's floor area in square metres**. A 15 m2 bedroom therefore wants about 75 m3/h at minimum - and comfortably more in high pollution. Manufacturer 'covers up to X sq ft' claims assume ideal, sealed conditions; in Delhi-NCR, buy one or two sizes larger than the box suggests.

Verified 2026 picks (prices move - confirm on the marketplace)

Model	CADR	Filter	Indicative price
Coway Airmega 150	~303 m3/h	True HEPA H13 + carbon	~Rs 16,999
Xiaomi Smart Air Purifier 4	~400 m3/h	HEPA H13 + carbon	~Rs 13,000-16,000
Honeywell Air Touch V5	~380 m3/h	HEPA H13 + carbon	~Rs 15,000-19,000
Honeywell Air Touch V1	~200 m3/h	HEPA H13 + carbon	budget pick, under Rs 10,000
Eureka Forbes 355	~355 m3/h	True HEPA H13 + carbon	~Rs 16,999
Qubo Q500	~250 m3/h	True HEPA H13 + carbon	~Rs 10,899
Levoit Core 300S	~240 m3/h	H13-grade + carbon	~Rs 9,999
Philips AC3220/60	~520 m3/h	True HEPA H13 + carbon	large-room pick
Dyson Purifier Cool TP09	~290 m3/h	Sealed H13 + formaldehyde	premium, ~Rs 54,900

Indicative 2026 Indian street prices from published reviews and listings; verify before buying. Filter replacement cost matters as much as the machine - budget roughly Rs 2,500-4,500 a year in a polluted city.

The strategy that actually works: one clean-air zone

You do not need to purify the whole house. Designate **one room** - ideally the bedroom, or a room where children and the elderly sleep - seal its gaps, close its windows, and run the purifier there. That 'clean-air room' is where you sleep and where vulnerable family members spend peak-pollution hours. Running one machine properly beats running several half-heartedly.

Mistakes that waste your money

- Buying on price alone without checking CADR against your room size.
- Choosing 'HEPA-type' over certified True HEPA H13.
- Expecting one purifier to clean an entire home - it is rated for one room.

- Ignoring the filter cost until the first replacement is due.
- Skipping pre-filter care - vacuum or wash it every two to four weeks to protect airflow and HEPA life.

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Part 7 - Fix your indoor air

Outdoor smog gets the headlines, but the air inside your home can be worse - because you add to it. Public-health agencies agree on the order of attack: **control the source first**, then ventilate, and only then filter. A purifier fighting an open incense stick or a smoky kitchen is a losing battle.

The kitchen

Cooking is a major, under-recognised source of indoor PM2.5. A 2025 study of urban homes in Bengaluru found that cooking contributed roughly **26% of daily indoor PM2.5 exposure**, that the **first hour after cooking** is the critical exposure window, and that gas stoves emitted nearly twice the PM2.5 of electric ones. Only about 15% of cooking events used a range hood. The fix is cheap: run an exhaust fan or chimney that vents outdoors every time you cook, open a window, and opening windows or using a hood more than doubled the rate at which PM2.5 cleared.

Burning things indoors - the big one

Incense, dhoop, mosquito coils, candles and tobacco all dump fine particles straight into the room you live in. Research has measured that burning a single mosquito coil can produce PM2.5 concentrations equivalent to smoking **75 to 137 cigarettes**, and that dhoop emits the most of the common household smokes. Keep these out of sealed rooms, and never use them in the room where a child, an elderly person or someone with asthma sleeps. Prefer mosquito nets and creams over coils in smog season.

Ventilate on a schedule, not by habit

- Open windows for short bursts during the **cleanest hours** (early afternoon), not at dawn or night.
- Wet-mop and wet-dust instead of dry sweeping - sweeping just lifts settled dust back into the air.
- Keep a doormat and remove shoes at the door to cut tracked-in dust.
- Fit a cheap filter sheet over air-conditioner pre-filters and clean it regularly - studies show it measurably cuts exposure.
- Keep the clean-air room sealed during peak hours; open it up only when the outside AQI is low.

Source control beats filtration

If you do only one thing indoors this winter: stop burning things in the rooms where you sleep. No incense, no dhoop, no coils, no candles, no smoking indoors. That single change can matter more than the model of purifier you buy.

SECTION

Part 8 - Protect your body

You cannot filter the whole city, but you can make your body more resilient to the pollution it cannot avoid. Doctors treating Indian smog-season patients converge on the same handful of habits.

Clear the pollutants you have already breathed in

- **Wash your face and rinse your nose** when you get home - it removes deposited particles from the skin and nasal passages.
- **Saline nasal rinse** (salt-water spray or a neti pot) is one of the better-evidenced measures: it clears pollutants from the nose and improves mucociliary clearance. Use it after outdoor exposure.
- **Steam inhalation** soothes inflamed airways and loosens secretions - a simple, low-risk habit on bad days.

Hydrate and eat for resilience

Cold air dries out the lining of your airways, making it easier for irritants to settle. Warm water, herbal teas and soups keep them moist. On the plate, focus on antioxidant-rich, anti-inflammatory foods that help the body repair oxidative damage from pollution: **amla, guava, oranges and other citrus** for vitamin C; **leafy greens** for protective phytonutrients; **omega-3** sources; and traditional helpers such as ginger, turmeric, tulsi and jaggery in moderation.

On supplements - the honest version

Vitamin C and NAC (N-acetylcysteine) are popular pollution 'shields', but they are not for everyone. For most healthy adults, vitamin C up to about 500 mg a day is generally considered safe, and NAC is typically used at 600 mg once or twice daily for short periods during severe episodes. People with kidney disorders, a history of kidney stones, sulfite-sensitive asthma, or who take long-term medication - and anyone pregnant or breastfeeding - should consult a doctor before using them. Treat these as short-term support, not a year-round habit, and never as a substitute for cutting your exposure.

Breathe better, on purpose

Breathing exercises strengthen the respiratory system and help clear the lungs. Ten minutes a day of **diaphragmatic breathing** (belly breathing), **pursed-lip breathing** and **pranayama** improves oxygen exchange and reduces breathlessness, especially for people with chronic lung conditions.

Exercise, sleep and the long game

- Move exercise indoors when AQI is above 200 - yoga, stretching and weights are fine indoors on bad days.
- Do not skip inhalers or prescribed medication; keep rescue medication within reach.
- Quit smoking - it compounds the damage of polluted air on the same lungs.
- Ask your doctor about **flu and pneumococcal vaccination**, which reduce the respiratory infections that pollution makes more likely.
- If you live in a high-pollution city or have a lung condition, get a lung-function check rather than waiting for symptoms.

SECTION

Part 9 - High-risk groups and red flags

Pollution is not equally dangerous to everyone. The same air that gives a healthy adult a scratchy throat can trigger a serious attack in someone whose lungs or heart are already under strain. If someone in your home falls into a group below, apply every protection in this playbook to them first, not last.

Group	Why they are at higher risk	Extra steps
Children	Lungs still developing; they breathe faster and deeper. No fine-tuning outdoors.	Child-sized N95 filter outdoors; keep indoors at peak hours; purifier in their room.
Elderly	Weaker immunity and existing conditions.	Stay indoors on Severe days; keep medication stocked; check on them daily.
Pregnant women	Exposure affects both mother and the developing baby.	Limiting outdoor time; use a clean-air room; follow medical advice.
Asthma / COPD	Airway inflammation; bronchospasm and mucus production.	Mask, purifier, adherence to inhalers, action plan ready.
Heart disease	Fine particles raise cardiovascular risk.	Avoid exertion outdoors; consult your doctor on bad-air days.

When to see a doctor

A mild cough that settles in a day or two is usually harmless. But seek medical help if you notice **persistent or worsening cough, breathlessness, chest pain, mucus production, or fever**. For people with asthma or COPD, warning signs are needing the inhaler more often, disturbed sleep from coughing, or finding routine activities harder.

Emergency signs - act immediately

Severe shortness of breath, sudden chest pain, bluish discolouration of the lips or fingernails, or confusion are medical emergencies. Go to hospital - do not wait for the air to improve.

SECTION

Part 10 - The Diwali 2026 plan

Diwali 2026 falls on **Sunday, 8 November 2026**. In Delhi-NCR, firecrackers and the crop-burning season combine to push AQI into the Severe band in the days around the festival. Here is where the legal position stood as this playbook was written, and how to protect your home regardless.

The 2026 firecracker position

- On **30 September 2026** the Supreme Court said it would **not impose a blanket ban** on firecrackers in Delhi-NCR, but would also **not allow round-the-clock bursting**. It signalled specific permitted time windows.
- The Court allowed the manufacture and sale of next-generation **joined green firecrackers ('ladi')** that meet CSIR-NEERI norms, and is examining which categories to permit.
- The question of **barium** in firecrackers was deferred, with the CPCB's report expected around **15 October 2026**; a separate order for Delhi is still to come.
- Bottom line: do not treat exact timings or permitted categories as final until the Court's detailed order is issued. Check the news in the first week of November.

Protect your home around Diwali

- **Before:** seal window gaps and run your purifier; stock N95 masks for anyone who must step out.
- **During:** keep windows shut, keep vulnerable family members in the clean-air room, and avoid adding your own indoor smoke (candles, incense, diyas in closed rooms).
- **After:** once the AQI improves, ventilate briefly, wet-clean surfaces, and rinse faces and noses.
- If you choose to celebrate with crackers, use only permitted green crackers in the allowed window - and remember the smoke stays in the air for hours after the noise stops.

SECTION

Part 11 - Your routine, plan and checklists

The daily 5-minute routine

When	Do this
Morning	Check the AQI. Decide: mask? outdoor exercise? windows open or shut?
Before any outing	Re-check the AQI; carry an N95 if it is above 150.
While cooking	Run the exhaust fan/chimney; open a window; keep children out of the kitchen.
On returning home	Wash face, rinse nose with saline, change out of outdoor clothes.
Evening	Close windows at peak pollution; run the purifier in the clean-air room.
Before bed	Purifier on in the bedroom; no incense, coils, candles or smoking indoors.

Your 30-day smog-season action plan

- **Week 1 - Measure and set up:** install an AQI app and note your locality's typical numbers; pick your clean-air room; if you have no purifier, shortlist one by CADR and True HEPA H13.
- **Week 2 - Cut indoor sources:** stop incense/coils/candles/smoking indoors; get your kitchen exhaust working; start wet-dusting instead of sweeping.
- **Week 3 - Protect your body:** buy N95 masks for the family; start saline nasal rinses and warm hydration; begin 10 minutes of breathing exercises a day; move exercise indoors on bad days.
- **Week 4 - Lock in the season:** set up the clean-air room fully; agree a Diwali plan; book a doctor visit for anyone with asthma, COPD or heart disease to review medication and vaccinations.

Print-and-stick checklist

1) AQI checked today 2) Mask in bag 3) Windows shut at peak 4) Purifier running in bedroom 5) No burning indoors 6) Saline rinse after outings 7) Vulnerable family indoors on Severe days 8) Inhalers/medicines stocked 9) Doctor's number handy.

SECTION

Quick-reference cheat sheet

AQI at a glance

AQI	Category	Your action
0-100	Good / Satisfactory	Normal activity; good time to ventilate.
101-200	Moderate	Sensitive people ease off outdoor exertion.
201-300	Poor	No outdoor exercise; mask on commutes; windows shut at peak.
301-400	Very Poor	Limit outdoor time; purifier on; protect children/elderly.
401-500	Severe	Stay in; mask if you must go out; reduce exposure now.

Buying shortcuts

- **Mask:** N95, KN95 or FFP2 - fit snugly. Cloth/surgical is not protection against PM2.5.
- **Purifier:** True HEPA H13 (or H14) plus activated carbon; CADR (m3/h) at least 5x room area in m2.
- **Monitor:** any cheap indoor PM2.5 monitor beats guessing.

Indoor rules that never change

- No incense, dhoop, mosquito coils, candles or smoking in rooms where people sleep.
- Kitchen exhaust on every time you cook.
- Wet-dust, don't dry-sweep.
- Ventilate in the cleanest hours, seal the clean-air room at peak hours.

SECTION

Sources and verification note

This playbook was compiled and fact-checked in October 2026. Where rules, prices or guidance change frequently, the source and the date are given so you can confirm the latest position before acting.

- **Air-quality categories and health impacts:** Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), National Air Quality Index - airquality.cpcb.gov.in.
- **Winter rules for Delhi-NCR:** Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) revised GRAP schedule approved 28 September 2026, and CAQM advisories - caqm.nic.in.
- **Firecrackers and Diwali:** Supreme Court proceedings of 30 September 2026 (Arjun Gopal v. Union of India), reported by national media; CPCB barium report expected 15 October 2026.
- **Diwali date:** 8 November 2026 (Lakshmi Puja, Pradosh Kaal, Delhi) - standard panchang sources.
- **Mask standards:** NIOSH (N95), GB2626 (KN95), EN 149 (FFP2); IQAir and peer-reviewed mask-efficiency studies.
- **Air purifiers:** published 2026 Indian buying guides and marketplace listings; HEPA H13/H14 and CADR specifications; filter-cost data from the same reviews.
- **Indoor air:** 2025 Bengaluru cooking-ventilation study; peer-reviewed Indian studies on mosquito coils, incense and dhoop; US EPA indoor air-quality guidance.
- **Health guidance:** WHO air-quality guidelines (PM2.5 annual 5 ug/m3, 24-hour 15 ug/m3) and Indian pulmonology and public-health commentary, 2025-2026.

One last word

No mask, purifier or supplement can make polluted air safe - they only reduce your exposure. The real fix is cleaner air for everyone. Until then, these steps are the practical difference between a rough season and a manageable one. Stay informed, protect the vulnerable first, and check the AQI before you step out.